Study Protocol: Exploring the community impact of Indigenous-language material holdings in academic libraries

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LIBR 507: Methods of Research Evaluation in Information Organizations

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The purpose of the present study is to investigate the impact of Indigenous language material holdings in academic libraries; it focuses on how community accessibility is affected by the storage and maintenance of these materials. Many case studies and literature reviews have been conducted on or about Indigenous languages in academic libraries (Bordonaro & Angalik, 2018; Ibacache, 2021; Johnston, 2007; Thorpe & Galassi, 2014; Turner, 2023). Results of these studies vary greatly depending on location, and little has been conducted on UBC's library, which creates the gap for the current research focus. While there is little literature in a British Columbian context, one article describes the process of a digitization project undertaken in partnership between Heiltsuk Cultural Education Centre, Bella Bella Community School, and the First Nations and Endangered Languages Program at the University of British Columbia (UBC) (Carpenter et al., 2021). This article provides some understanding of the process of collaboration between UBC and a BC First Nation, and the role that digitization can play in language revitalization. The rise of digitization as a common way to increase access to information offers a compelling research question on how effective the reach of digitized language materials is at UBC.

With the increased momentum of Indigenous language revitalization efforts, the onus is on academic institutions to ensure that they align their collections, policies and access strategies with the needs of Indigenous communities. This project is principally concerned with hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ language materials at the University of British Columbia (UBC), and seeks to examine how they can be improved in their organization, maintenance and accessibility in collaboration with the Musqueam community, who have been investing in revitalization efforts since the 1970s (Musqueam Indian Band [MIB], 2024).

Musqueam community's language, hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓, is integral to their cultural identity and knowledge systems. As such, Musqueam has asked UBC libraries to assess and enhance their hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ holdings so as to ensure that community members have increased access and authority over these materials. Our research places emphasis on Musqueam voices by connecting with language learners, elders, and community members to collect their perspectives and priorities.

Methodology

This study utilizes a qualitative, community-centered approach. This ensures that Musqueam knowledge holders guide the research process as well as outcomes. The study adopts the following methods:

- Moderated Group Discussion: We will converse with Musqueam community members to gain an insight into their experiences with hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ language materials at UBC. Additionally, we will inquire about any accessibility challenges and recommendations for improvement.
- Questionnaire: A short survey will be designed to gather insights from the broader community about the use and accessibility of hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ language materials.
- Collaborative Report for UBC Libraries: A research document will be prepared assembling Musqueam priorities and recommendations for enhancing UBC's hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ language holdings, which will ensure that changes give consideration to community needs and the principles of data sovereignty.

Data Analysis Plan

The study adopts qualitative thematic analysis which means that we will examine the transcripts of the moderated group discussions to determine repeated themes and code them into categories (e.g., Elders, cultural protocols, social media interaction, etc.). We will also analyze responses to questionnaires to determine patterns in the utilization of materials as well as accessibility concerns. We will then consolidate results from both sources into a final report in an effort to have UBC library policies informed directly by community insights.

Sample

Recruitment for the sample will use non-probability snowball sampling. We will collaborate with UBC's First Nations and Endangered Languages program and the Musqueam Nation to recruit the initial participants. Participants will be told that we are interested in working with them to hear about their

views and opinions on hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ language materials stored at UBC Libraries. The study will be promoted as a two-hour compensated group interview akin to a focus group, with an opportunity to be involved in further research. We will ask the initial participants to consider sharing this study with anyone they think may be interested in participating. Our goal is for the sample of participants to be made up of members of the Musqueam community and while our study focuses on using language materials, we will not limit participation to only hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ speakers, as we value input from anyone who is willing to provide it. We aim to have five to six participants in each of our four sessions.

The goal for recruitment is to be as collaborative with the participants as they are willing to be to ensure that the research is reciprocal and not extractive. Part of this has involved forming a relationship with the Musqueam Nation prior to beginning the study and consulting with members of the community about the best way to sample and to compensate participants.[1] We will also recognize the labour of asking participants to recruit further participants and offer compensation for each referral.

Procedure

Musqueam community members and other people with an interest in hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ will be contacted by Musqueam Band, UBC's First Nations and Endangered Language program, or by individual referral. Prospective participants are encouraged to share the research details with relevant family, friends and colleagues. Interested participants reach out to the research team, and can sign-up for one of four in-person meetings (one at Musqueam, one at UBC, one in downtown Vancouver, and one online). In the sign-up process, participants are asked to review a consent form (Appendix A: Consent Form). Prior to the group interview, participants are given general questions to reflect on as preparation, and are welcomed to ask any questions. At this time, participants are asked to fill out a very brief questionnaire (Appendix B: Questionnaire). They also have the option to fill this out in person at the in-person registration.

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[1] Assuming this is a research protocol being submitted to a REB, the research team would have already been in conversation with Musqueam, and been given a research permit (Appendix E: Musqueam Band Research Permit).

To make everyone comfortable, the gathering will incorporate tea and refreshments, and will involve participants and researchers sitting in a circle around a kitchen-style table, with appropriate measures taken for accessibility. After the land acknowledgement and the researchers sharing a bit about where we are coming from, we will review the consent form again, and explain how the opt-in at any time works, and how participants will be given opportunities to review and speak back to transcripts, drafts, and the final article before publication. We will also field questions or comments.

The semi-structured group interview will be conducted by Josh, following the themes and talking points outlined in Appendix C: Interview Script and Questions, related to:

- General experience
- Access and usability
- Obstacles and hurdles
- Effects and improvements
- Community governance and future directions

Meanwhile, Farzad will manage the recording and Simeon will make notes to facilitate connecting individual speakers to what is shared (for ongoing consent purposes). The goal is to foster an atmosphere of collaboration and rich conversation, where everyone feels open to share their experience with hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓, particularly around educational institutions that have historically and in ongoing ways, worked against celebrating Indigenous languages. All interviews are scheduled for approximately 90 minutes, with time built in for naturally occurring overtime (up to two hours), if the conversation is good and people are happy to stay (no one is required to remain for the entire time). Narrative "tangents" are encouraged.

At the conclusion of the group interview, we will thank each individual for their contributions, and see whether there are further questions or concerns about the meeting or our work. We will offer a brochure outlining next steps and our contacts (Appendix D: Debrief Handout). In a follow-up email we

will reiterate our gratitude, including an e-transfer voucher for $36 CAD, and an invitation to a dinner where we will present our initial findings.

All three of us will compile the transcription notes. The notes for each individual will be sent to the appropriate participant, and they will have a chance to review, edit, and redact what they have said.

Ethical Considerations

Prior to data collection and after, participants will be given a chance to opt in to various levels of confidentiality. Opting in will mean that participants will be referred to by name in the paper. Participants who opt out will be given a pseudonym. Each participant will be given an associated code on a spreadsheet as well as their confidentiality wishes noted beside their name. This spreadsheet will only be used as a way to track participants, or should participants wish to withdraw their data then the spreadsheet will also be used, but the spreadsheet will never be publicized. Participants will also be offered a separate opt in to later collaboration in the study on the research side, should they opt in this will give them the ability to receive weekly updates and provide their insight on how the direction of the research should go.

The spreadsheet containing information about participant identities will be a printed piece of paper stored in a binder and filled out with a pen. The binder will be stored in a secured location. This ensures that the sheets can later be shredded and keeps any identifying information off of the cloud. Data which has been removed from any identifying features, aside from those who opted in to using their first name, will be stored on a collaborative OneDrive account. By storing this on the cloud, it allows those participants who opted in to collaboration an ability to see the data and any progress being made. The data collected and control of the research will belong to the Musqueam community, recognizing the fundamental principles of OCAP®, which is set out as a minimum consideration for data work with First Nations. OCAP® is a registered trademark of the First Nations Information Governance Centre (FNIGC) (FNIGC, n.d.).

Informed consent will be obtained by asking participants to sign a consent sheet. The researcher will inform the participants about the study and the different aspects of confidentiality and involvement they can choose, then the researcher will hand the sheets to the participants. These consent forms will be stored in the same location as the binder which contains the identifying information of participants. We have also consulted with the Musqueam Indian Band, and received an MIB research permit allowing a year for this study.

Approach to Data Analysis

We expect to receive two sets of data. One from our group interviews, and another set from our short questionnaires. The short questionnaire survey data will be analyzed both quantitatively (questions #1-3) and qualitatively (questions #4-5). For the latter two questions we will be using thematic analysis to identify common themes. This analysis will be done by all three researchers to first create a consensus of the themes appearing in survey responses. Survey responses will then be coded according to themes.

Simeon and Josh will make transcriptions, and Farzad will double-check the names. For any outstanding specificities regarding language or culture we will reach out to and consult with Jill Campbell, the coordinator of the Musqueam Language and Culture department of the MIB. We strive to center the experiences and perception of each group session participant, while also drawing out shared themes. We will analyze the session transcripts through the interpretive phenomenological analysis outlined in Tai (2023), going through iterative cycles of questioning, reflecting, and interpreting via motifs of meaning-making participants describe. We also made use of the value impact frameworks described in Liew et al. (2021) in analyzing digital Maori language tools. A third, important aspect will be looking at what participants share through Musqueam snəw̓eyəɬ (teachings) so as to be able to talk about values and principles inherent to Musqueam. While this will be done by our research partners at Musqueam, our research team has found Wilson's work (2016) on Musqueam community gathering together and learning from indirect storytelling indispensable.

Team Contributions

Intro	FA
Intro (Literature)	JT
Methods & Data analysis plan	FA
Sampling Strategy	JT
Procedure	SF
Ethical Protocols	JT
Data Analysis	JT & SF
References	JT & SF
Designed Consent form	FA
Designed debrief	SF
Created short questionnaire	FA
Created guided discussion questions	FA & SF
MIB research permit (modified)	SF
Editing & Review	JT, FA, SF

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Appendix A

Consent Form

Title of Research Project: Exploring the Community Impact of Indigenous-Language Material Holdings in Academic Libraries

Principal Researchers: Farzad Amirmahani, Josh Thompson, Simeon Faehndrich

Purpose of the Study:

This study is intended to explore and understand how storage and conservation of Indigenous language materials in university libraries both affect the availability of such materials for the community. Specifically, the study focuses on Musqueam community members through their access and interaction with hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ language collections at the University of British Columbia, or UBC. The findings and outcomes emanating from this research undertaking will make an important contribution towards the production of advice and guidelines on how to enhance access and management processes in relation to these resources.

Participation and Procedures:

- Participation entails a moderated group discussion (90–120 minutes) and/or a short questionnaire concerning prior experiences with hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ language materials.
- We will audio-record the discussions, and transcribe the responses for analysis.
- Your participation is completely voluntary, and you can terminate your participation at any time with no repercussions.
- You will have the option to opt in or out of various levels of confidentiality and collaboration (see below).

Confidentiality & Data Use Options

Please review and choose the options that align with your preferences:

1. **Confidentiality Preferences**

   ☐ *I consent to the use of my name for identification in the study (opt-in to full transparency).*

   ☐ *I would rather be provided with a pseudonym in the study (opt-out of full transparency).*

2. **Collaboration Preferences**

   ☐ *I agree to participate in ongoing collaboration and updates on the study. I would like to receive updates on a weekly basis and give feedback on research progress.*

☐ *I prefer not to participate in ongoing collaboration after this session.*

Data Security & Storage

- Participants' confidentiality preferences will be tracked using a safe, offline spreadsheet, which also enables withdrawal requests to be honoured.
- A printed copy of the participant tracking data will be kept in a safe place in a closed binder. This guarantees that after the study is over, the data can be destroyed.
- For research purposes, anonymized data will be kept on a UBC OneDrive account.
- Ongoing study progress will only be visible to individuals who choose to collaborate.

Consent Statement

☐ *I have read and understood the purpose and details of this study. I willingly accept to participate.*

☐ *I am aware that I can withdraw at any time without penalty.*

☐ *I understand how my confidentiality preferences and data will be treated as outlined above.*

☐ *I consent to being audio-recorded.*

Participant's Name (Printed):

Participant's Signature:

Date:

Appendix B

Questionnaire

This short questionnaire aims to find out about participants' experiences with Indigenous language materials in academic libraries.

1. **Have you ever utilized Indigenous-language materials in an academic library?** (Yes/No)
2. **If yes, what types of materials have you utilized?** (Tick all that apply)

☐ Books

☐ Audio-visual materials (e.g., recordings, films)

☐ Digital resources (e.g., online dictionaries, archives)

☐ Teaching materials (e.g., language workbooks, instructional guides)

☐ Other (please elaborate)

3. **How often do you utilize Indigenous-language materials?**

☐ Frequently (at least once a month)

☐ Occasionally (a few times a year)

☐ Rarely (once a year or less)

☐ Never

4. **What are some of the challenges you have experienced in trying to access Indigenous-language materials?** (Open-ended)

5. **What would make it easier for you to access and use Indigenous-language materials?** (Open-ended)

Appendix C

Interview Script and Questions

Thank you for taking the time to be part of this discussion. The key aim of our study is to gain a better understanding of how the preservation and maintenance of material published in Indigenous languages in university libraries influence the accessibility of the material for the members of the community. We are eager to learn about your personal experiences, to know more about the types of challenges you have faced in this area, and to gain any thoughtful recommendations that you may have to contribute to meaningful change.

Discussion Questions:

General Experience:

- Can you share an experience when you utilized Indigenous-language materials in a library?
- How did you find it?
- How do these resources play a part in your community networks?
- Are there spiritual connections in the way you use these resources? What about the role of identity?

Access and usability:

- How easy or hard was it to locate and utilize these resources?
- What is the role of digital resources in accessing Indigenous-language materials?
- Other topics (if there is time): how did you find out about these resources (i.e. publicity)? What are the primary devices you use for access? Are there concerns around older adults and/or language-barriers (e.g. in search functions)?

Obstacles and Hurdles:

- Have you faced any challenges in obtaining Indigenous-language materials?
- Are there any cultural or institutional barriers to accessing these materials?
- Have you come across material that you felt was culturally sensitive and should have been restricted in some way?
- Do you consider using hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ material from communities other than Musqueam, or material in Halq̓eméylem or Hul̓q̓umín̓um̓?

Effects and Improvements:

- In what ways does access to Indigenous-language resources in libraries help support language revitalization?
- What are the ways you are using, reusing, and repurposing these resources?
- What would you like to see happen differently in how academic libraries manage Indigenous-language materials?

Community Governance and Future Directions:

- What is the role of Indigenous communities in deciding how language materials are accessed and stored?
- Are there certain practices or policies that you would prefer libraries to embrace?

Closing Statement:

Thank you for your input; your comments are truly precious to inform our understanding of how academic libraries can support Indigenous language accessibility and revitalization. If you have any additional reflections or would like to follow up, please do not hesitate to be in touch.

Appendix D

Debrief Handout

We are enormously grateful for your contributions today, including sharing your language, culture, and traditions. We also honour the enormity of the work of dismantling the ongoing effects of colonization on Musqueam, particularly through investing in revitalizing hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ and Musqueam ways of being. You will be receiving compensation as an e-transfer voucher by email. Please contact us if you would like this in another form, or do not receive it.

This page highlights some of the ways you can stay involved if you are interested in the evolving ways UBC and Musqueam are partnering to revitalize hən̓q̓əmin̓əm̓ through digital tools.

1. ***Musqueam 101***: held on Wednesday nights at the Elders Centres through the winter, this will be our chance to share updates and our final lay report with Musqueam, so look out for updates online at https://www.musqueam.bc.ca/our-story/educational-resources/musqueam-101/
2. ***Follow-up dinner***: once the research team has compiled all the stories shared, and some of the themes have been highlighted, we'd like to get your feedback, so we are inviting you all to a dinner table discussion, scheduled for March 31st 2026 (National Indigenous Languages Day) at Green College.
3. ***Indigenous Community Borrower card***: if you can't wait to dive into some of the material already at UBC, you are eligible for a community borrower card to all UBC library branches. The research team is working to make digital resources available for Indigenous community borrowers off campus. https://services.library.ubc.ca/borrowing-services/get-library-access/unaffiliated/#IndigenousCommunity-1

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Appendix E

Musqueam Band Research Permit[2]

Musqueam Band Council - Permit to Conduct Sociological Research on Musqueam, Traditional Territory (Permit Number 2025-3 MB)

4.1 Musqueam Council on behalf of the Musqueam Indian Band will receive a copy of the final report and related research.

4.2 All contact with the Musqueam Indian Band administration and band members will be initiated through the Band's designated person.

4.3 The research team will give periodic updates on research progress to the Band's representative.

4.4 The draft report is to be made available to the Band representative for review and comment prior to submission for peer review.

4.5 Participation in the project is voluntary and any participant being interviewed can withdraw at any time.

4.6 Individual participants can choose if the interview is tape recorded or not, and can determine if tapes or draft records of interviews are to be saved, destroyed or donated to the Musqueam Indian Band.

4.7 The research team will seek written consent from each participant in a form that explains the nature and purpose of the research.

4.8 All individuals interviewed will receive copies of their information for review and comment prior to finalization of the report.

4.9 The research team will provide to the persons interviewed copies of all data, documents, reports, summaries, and tapes that result from the research conducted as well as those pages relating to the individuals interviewed as they will appear in the final report.

4.10 The duration of the permit is from April 06, 2025 to April 05, 2026.

4.11 The final document will be in a form useful to the community, as a return or exchange for their participation in the research.

4.12 This permit can be amended and/or withdrawn at any time. Publication in any other form requires the prior written approval of the participants.

4.13 The research team is authorized to make contact with band members through the band representative.

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[2] This fictional research permit is based on actual MIB research permit from theses on Musqueam held on UBC's cIRcle repository.

Statement on use of Generative AI:

We confirm that we did not use generative AI tools/services to author this submission